

The art of protest

THEATRE

Imphal | MANIPUR



Born amidst chaos, a theatre company from Manipur travels all over the world and attracts it as well to its remote charms

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

Manipur makes it to national news for all the wrong reasons—insurgency, student protests and alleged army violations. But in the midst of the ruins of a peaceable state is a flourishing theatre culture, the depths of which are as unmatched as its variety. From Kanhailal and his Kalakshetra that immortalised the tale of Pebet, a discourse on cultural changes to Lokendra Arambham who performed Shakespeare's *Macbeth* in Manipuri in the UK, to Ratan Thiyam's Chorus Repertory Theatre that draws from the 'theatre of roots', art here has been surrounded by, yet survived, strife.

And Thiyam is its genius orchestrator. The 67-year old believes art is the only means of protest left. From remote Imphal, the group travels all over the world. Long before Yanni performed at the Taj Mahal, Thiyam's group performed at the Acropolis in Greece and has had visitors like Peter Brook, the creator of *Mahabharata*. "The feeling that somewhere, something has gone wrong is one that I constantly experience as an artiste, and I try to express that through my work," says Thiyam. Which explains why his recent performances have been awash with the colour red. His cry for

peace has contemporarised epic tales like *Chakravyuh*, the tale of Abhimanyu, and *Uttara Priyadarshi*, the tale of Emperor Ashoka. On *Nine Hills One Valley* which premiered in Delhi, his mentor from the National School of Drama and one of India's most acclaimed theatre personalities, Ebrahim Alkazi said, "With this one play, you've managed to outdo what I did in my entire life as a theatre artist." The super skilled actors at Chorus specialise in everything from carpentry to cooking, besides running through their roles and braving another day in a state torn by

"ART HAS TO REPRESENT THE TIMES THAT WE LIVE IN; THIS DOES NOT MEAN THAT WE HAVE TO BECOME ACTIVISTS."

RATAN THIYAM

uncertainty. "Every morning is a challenge. I've had a gun pointed at my head by the security forces, one of my actors was detained and arrested, before being released. Everyday, we are made to feel like second class citizens in our own land," says Thiyam of his dramatic struggle.

REALITY ONSTAGE:
Abhimanyu's story in *Chakravyuh*

